

FormX — Front Lot Line Assignment Logic

Per-jurisdiction rules for determining the legal front of a multi-street lot

Source data generated 2026-08-27 · 23 Bay Area jurisdictions · Prepared for legal review, 2026-08-30

1. Purpose and scope

FormX's edge-labeling engine assigns each edge of a parcel a legal role (front, street side, interior side, rear) as an input to ADU/SFR setback checks. For lots abutting a single street the front is unambiguous. For corner lots, through lots, and other multi-street lots, the legal front depends on how each jurisdiction's municipal code declares it. This document sets out, for each of the 23 jurisdictions currently supported, the rule the engine applies and the municipal code citation it is based on, together with the default applied when a jurisdiction is not in the dataset. We request confirmation that (a) each per-jurisdiction rule correctly reflects the cited code section, and (b) the default rule is a defensible fallback.

Every rule below is marked source = "code", meaning it was verified against the municipal code section quoted in the citation column (via the code platform listed for that jurisdiction).

2. Rule taxonomy

Each jurisdiction is assigned exactly one base rule from the following five categories:

Rule	Meaning
Shortest frontage shortest_frontage	The front lot line is the shorter (narrower) of the lot lines abutting a street. Where the code assigns ties or irregular lots to a planning official, that is noted in the citation.
Address street address_street	The front is the street named in the parcel's situs address.
Designated by the jurisdiction designated	The front (or principal frontage) is designated by the jurisdiction — by district standards, by home/driveway orientation, or by a planning body — rather than derived from geometry.
Owner-elected owner_elected	The property owner may elect which street lot line is the front, in some cases subject to concurrence by a planning official.
All street frontages are fronts all_fronts	Every street frontage of the lot is treated as a front; the code applies its front (street-line) setback to each street frontage rather than declaring a single front.

3. Default rule (jurisdiction not in dataset)

When a parcel falls in a jurisdiction not present in this dataset, the engine defaults to the **address street** rule: the street named in the parcel's situs address is treated as the front. If no parcel edge matches the address street, the engine falls back to the **shortest frontage** rule.

4. Conditional overrides

A jurisdiction record may carry an ordered list of overrides: conditions under which a different rule displaces the base rule, each with its own citation. The engine evaluates overrides before the base rule. If an override's condition cannot be evaluated (for example, the zoning district is unknown) and no other override applies, the engine falls back to the

address-street default rather than the base rule, and flags the lookup (*front_rule_override_unevaluated*) for review. Currently only San Jose carries overrides; they are detailed in its entry in Section 6.

5. Summary of assignments

Jurisdiction	County	Rule	Primary citation
Lafayette	Contra Costa	Designated by the jurisdiction	LMC 6-566(b)(2)
Moraga	Contra Costa	Designated by the jurisdiction	MMC 8.68.090
Orinda	Contra Costa	Shortest frontage	OMC 17.4.8
Fairfax	Marin	Shortest frontage	TC 17.010.110(B) (Ord. 885, 11-1-2023)
Mill Valley	Marin	Designated by the jurisdiction	MMC 20.90.030(A)(12)
Sausalito	Marin	Owner-elected	SMC 10.88
Napa	Napa	Shortest frontage	NMC 17.06.030
Atherton	San Mateo	Address street	AMC 17.52.040(F)(7)
Hillsborough	San Mateo	All street frontages are fronts	HMC 17.24.020(A)
Menlo Park	San Mateo	Owner-elected	MPMC 16.04.405
Portola Valley	San Mateo	Owner-elected	PVMC 18.04.350
San Carlos	San Mateo	Shortest frontage	SCMC 18.41.020
San Mateo	San Mateo	Owner-elected	SMMC 27.04.300(a)
San Mateo County (unincorporated)	San Mateo	Shortest frontage	County zoning Def. 80
Los Altos	Santa Clara	Shortest frontage	LAMC 14.02.010 Lot line
Los Altos Hills	Santa Clara	Designated by the jurisdiction	LAHMC 10-1.505(c)(2)
Mountain View	Santa Clara	Shortest frontage	MVCC 36.60.27
Palo Alto	Santa Clara	Owner-elected	PAMC 18.09.040(j)(4) corner-lot election (10 ft street side / 16 ft front)
San Jose	Santa Clara	Shortest frontage *	SJMC 20.200.700
Saratoga	Santa Clara	Shortest frontage	SMC 15-06.430(a)
Sunnyvale	Santa Clara	All street frontages are fronts	SMC 19.12.260(1)(a)
Healdsburg	Sonoma	Shortest frontage	HMC 20.28.310
Windsor	Sonoma	Shortest frontage	Zoning Ord. 27.60.020

* Subject to conditional overrides — see the jurisdiction's detail entry in Section 6.

6. Per-jurisdiction detail and citations

Each entry below reproduces the rule, code citation, and ordinance source exactly as encoded in the engine's jurisdiction dataset (zoning_ordinance_links.json). Long citation notes documenting the verification reasoning are reproduced in full.

Contra Costa County

Lafayette

Rule	Designated by the jurisdiction (designated)
Source	Verified in municipal code
Citation	LMC 6-566(b)(2) - principal frontage per district; secondary frontage 4 ft for Class C ADUs
Code access	Municode — https://library.municode.com/ca/lafayette/codes/code_of_ordinances?nodeId=TIT6PLLAUS

Moraga

Rule	Designated by the jurisdiction (designated)
Source	Verified in municipal code
Citation	MMC 8.68.090 - front lot line = principal street
Code access	Zoneomics code viewer — https://www.zoneomics.com/code/moraga-CA

Orinda

Rule	Shortest frontage (shortest_frontage)
Source	Verified in municipal code
Citation	OMC 17.4.8 - shorter frontage is generally the front
Code access	Zoneomics code viewer — https://www.zoneomics.com/code/orinda-CA

Marin County

Fairfax

Rule	Shortest frontage (shortest_frontage)
Source	Verified in municipal code
Citation	TC 17.010.110(B) (Ord. 885, 11-1-2023) - "The front of a corner lot is the narrowest dimension of the lot with street frontage"; this is the operative front declaration. 17.010.120(B) refers to a "corner side yard", confirming one front plus one street side. Street-side treatment: 17.040.020(D) gives all street frontage of any corner lot a 10 ft setback, which equals the 10 ft front yard setback in 17.040.020(A), so the numeric outcome is identical either way - this entry was previously labeled all_frons on the strength of 17.040.020(D), but that is a setback rule, not a front declaration. Ch. 17.008 defines CORNER LOT as "a lot in the junction of and fronting on two or more intersecting streets" (locational, not operative) and never defines "front lot line"; 17.010.110(B) fills that gap. Caveat: 17.040.020 preamble is ambiguously drafted ("no accessory structure or building...") and per-district primary-dwelling setbacks were not traced.
Code access	Zoneomics code viewer — https://www.zoneomics.com/code/fairfax-CA

Mill Valley

Rule	Designated by the jurisdiction (designated)
Source	Verified in municipal code
Citation	MMC 20.90.030(A)(12) - primary frontage by driveway/home orientation; remaining street frontage is the side yard
Code access	Zoneomics code viewer — https://www.zoneomics.com/code/mill-valley-CA

Sausalito

Rule	Owner-elected (owner_elected)
Source	Verified in municipal code
Citation	SMC 10.88 - owner elects the front street line with Director concurrence
Code access	Zoneomics code viewer — https://www.zoneomics.com/code/sausalito-CA

Napa County

Napa

Rule	Shortest frontage (shortest_frontage)
Source	Verified in municipal code
Citation	NMC 17.06.030 - on a corner lot the front line is the shorter of any two adjacent street lot lines
Code access	Zoneomics code viewer — https://www.zoneomics.com/code/napa-CA

San Mateo County

Atherton

Rule	Address street (address_street)
Source	Verified in municipal code
Citation	AMC 17.52.040(F)(7) - front designated by the address street on corner/double-frontage lots
Code access	Municipal.codes (OpenGov) — https://atherton.municipal.codes/Code/17

Hillsborough

Rule	All street frontages are fronts (all_fronts)
Source	Verified in municipal code
Citation	HMC 17.24.020(A) - 25 ft street-line setback on every street frontage; no front concept
Code access	Municode — https://library.municode.com/ca/hillsborough/codes/code_of_ordinances?nodeId=TIT17ZO

Menlo Park

Rule	Owner-elected (owner_elected)
Source	Verified in municipal code
Citation	MPMC 16.04.405 - owner may elect the front lot line on corner lots
Code access	Code Publishing — https://www.codepublishing.com/CA/MenloPark/html/MenloPark16/MenloPark16.html

Portola Valley

Rule	Owner-elected (owner_elected)
Source	Verified in municipal code
Citation	PVMC 18.04.350 - owner may elect any street parcel line as front, with town planner concurrence; flag lots: line nearest and most nearly parallel to the street
Code access	Municode — https://library.municode.com/ca/portola_valley/codes/code_of_ordinances?nodeId=TIT18ZO

San Carlos

Rule	Shortest frontage (shortest_frontage)
Source	Verified in municipal code
Citation	SCMC 18.41.020 - corner lot front = the shorter lot line abutting a street; flag lots: interior line nearest and most parallel to the access street
Code access	Zoneomics code viewer — https://zoneomics.com/code/san-carlos-CA

San Mateo

Rule	Owner-elected (owner_elected)
Source	Verified in municipal code
Citation	SMMC 27.04.300(a) - on a corner lot the owner may elect either street property line as the front; through lots: both street lines are fronts (27.04.275(d))
Code access	City-hosted — https://law.cityofsanmateo.org/us/ca/cities/san-mateo/code/27

San Mateo County (unincorporated)

Rule	Shortest frontage (shortest_frontage)
Source	Verified in municipal code
Citation	County zoning Def. 80 - front lot line = the narrowest lot frontage
Code access	Zoneomics code viewer — https://www.zoneomics.com/code/san-mateo-county-unincorporated-CA

Santa Clara County

Los Altos

Rule	Shortest frontage (shortest_frontage)
Source	Verified in municipal code
Citation	LAMC 14.02.010 Lot line - corner lot front = shortest dimension fronting the street; either line allowed only if both remain conforming; flag lots: interior line nearest and most parallel to the access street
Code access	Municode — https://library.municode.com/ca/los_altos/codes/code_of_ordinances?nodeId=TIT14ZO

Los Altos Hills

Rule	Designated by the jurisdiction (designated)
Source	Verified in municipal code
Citation	LAHMC 10-1.505(c)(2) - Planning Commission designates the 40-ft street on multi-street lots
Code access	Zoneomics code viewer — https://www.zoneomics.com/code/los-altos-hills-CA

Mountain View

Rule	Shortest frontage (shortest_frontage)
Source	Verified in municipal code
Citation	MVCC 36.60.27 - corner lot front = shortest frontage unless the owner designates the longer at time of development; through lots: both lines are fronts
Code access	Municode — https://library.municode.com/ca/mountain_view/codes/code_of_ordinances?nodeId=PTIIT_HCO_CH36ZO

Palo Alto

Rule	Owner-elected (owner_elected)
Source	Verified in municipal code
Citation	PAMC 18.09.040(j)(4) corner-lot election (10 ft street side / 16 ft front)
Code access	Zoneomics code viewer — https://www.zoneomics.com/code/palo-alto-CA

San Jose

Rule	Shortest frontage (shortest_frontage)
Source	Verified in municipal code
Citation	SJMC 20.200.700 - "Front lot line of a corner lot" is the narrower lot line abutting a public or private right-of-way; "Side corner lot line of a corner lot" is the longer of the two. This is the default and it governs the ordinary corner lot. The entry was previously labeled all_fronts on the strength of 20.30.210(A), but that section is conditional ("If a lot exceeds the defined dimensions of a corner lot") and describes the exception, not the rule - see front_rule.overrides. 20.30.210(B) gives the director of planning final say on irregular or greater-than-four-sided lots, with a floor of one front and one rear property line.
Code access	Zoneomics code viewer — https://www.zoneomics.com/code/san-jose-CA
Override 1	Override 1 — applies rule "All street frontages are fronts" when condition <i>oversized_corner_lot</i> holds. Citation: SJMC 20.200.670(A); restated at 20.30.210(A) A lot that exceeds the corner-lot dimension thresholds is not a corner lot and is deemed to have two front property lines. Thresholds: 120 ft in residential districts, 150 ft in commercial districts. BOTH street frontages must exceed the threshold; a lot exceeding on only one frontage remains an ordinary corner lot with a single (narrower) front. Dimension thresholds: residential districts — 120 ft; commercial districts — 150 ft
Override 2	Override 2 — applies rule "All street frontages are fronts" when condition <i>pedestrian_oriented_district</i> holds. Citation: SJMC 20.200.670(B) In a pedestrian oriented zoning district a corner lot has a minimum of two front lot lines regardless of the dimensions of the lot. Applies notwithstanding 20.200.670(A), so it is not gated on lot size. zone_codes lists the districts: Ch. 20.75 regulates the MS main street districts (MS-G, MS-C), established in Table 20-20 of 20.10.060 and applicable only within the Alum Rock Neighborhood Business District (20.75.020(A)). Ambiguity not resolved: DC/DC-NT1 (downtown, Ch. 20.70) and CP "Commercial Pedestrian" (Ch. 20.40) are NOT treated as pedestrian oriented districts here, since 20.75.010 is the chapter that carries the label; revisit if the city applies 20.200.670(B) more broadly. Applicable zoning districts: MS-G, MS-C

Saratoga

Rule	Shortest frontage (shortest_frontage)
Source	Verified in municipal code
Citation	SMC 15-06.430(a) - corner lot front = shortest dimension fronting the street; flag lots: interior line nearest the access street; Director assigns lines on irregular lots
Code access	Municode — https://library.municode.com/ca/saratoga/codes/code_of_ordinances?nodeId=CH15ZORE

Sunnyvale

Rule	All street frontages are fronts (all_fronts)
Source	Verified in municipal code
Citation	SMC 19.12.260(1)(a) - front yard parallels "the street or streets upon which the lot abuts", so every street line of a corner lot is a front; 19.12.260(1)(b) - rear yard is opposite the narrower frontage, making the short frontage the primary front; 19.12.130(18) - lot width measured at the "required front yard", i.e. the one not reducible under 19.34.040; 19.34.040(b) - front yard on the longer street frontage reducible to 9 ft in R-0/R-1/R-1.5 (and duplex/SFR in R-2) where streets intersect at 60 degrees or more; Table 19.79.070 carries a separate "Reducible front (longer street frontage of corner lots)" row for ADUs
Code access	eCode360 (General Code) — https://ecode360.com/42729480

Sonoma County

Healdsburg

Rule	Shortest frontage (shortest_frontage)
Source	Verified in municipal code
Citation	HMC 20.28.310 - front = line separating the narrower street frontage of a corner lot from a street (verified from Nov 2024 archive; live eCode360 gated)
Code access	Zoneomics code viewer — https://www.zoneomics.com/code/healdsburg-CA

Windsor

Rule	Shortest frontage (shortest_frontage)
Source	Verified in municipal code
Citation	Zoning Ord. 27.60.020 - corner-lot front = shortest frontage (Director decides ties); through lots: both street lines are fronts; flag-lot front setback Director-determined (27.20.070(C)(1))
Code access	Zoneomics code viewer — https://www.zoneomics.com/code/windsor-CA

7. Requested review

Please confirm or comment on each of the following. Any correction to a rule or citation will be applied to the engine's jurisdiction dataset and takes effect for all subsequent parcel evaluations.

1. For each jurisdiction in Section 6, the assigned rule correctly characterizes how the cited code section declares the front lot line of a corner or other multi-street lot.
2. The San Jose conditional overrides (oversized corner lots; MS-G/MS-C pedestrian-oriented districts) are correctly scoped, including the reading that both street frontages must exceed the dimension threshold and the decision not to treat DC, DC-NT1, or CP districts as pedestrian oriented.
3. The Fairfax entry's reading — 17.010.110(B) as the operative front declaration, with 17.040.020(D) treated as a setback rule rather than a front declaration — is correct.
4. The default for unlisted jurisdictions (address street, falling back to shortest frontage when no edge matches the address street) is a reasonable and defensible fallback.
5. The override-unevaluable fallback (revert to the address-street default and flag for review) is an acceptable conservative behavior.

Reviewed and approved by:

Date:

Signature:

Firm:
